

What really is the strong point for Pidgin is plugins. Right-click on the Pidgin icon on the taskbar and click on Plugins. Read the descriptions right there and select the plugins you want. Some add basic functionalities like the ability to store notes about your contacts, or configure how long after you should be shown idle. Some are smart: the Text Replacement window keeps checking for user-defined misspellings and sends out the correct phrase, also defined by the user. So for example, if you have this habit of typing “it snot” instead of “it’s not” and are fed up of getting emoticons from friends wondering about stuff better not thought out, this is a lifesaver. Other supported features are encrypting chats using RSA and grouping multiple contacts under a single name so that group messaging becomes easy.



Text replacement rules, for those key misses

4.2.2 Trillian

This is a proprietary multi-protocol IM client that comes in two versions: Basic (free) and Pro (for a fee—\$25, or Rs 1,000). It is currently Windows-only (XP and Vista). It supports multiple chat services like AIM, ICQ, Windows Live Messenger, and Yahoo! Messenger for both Basic and Pro versions, while additional support for IRC, Novell GroupWare Messenger, IRC, Jabber, and Skype is available in the Pro version. Trillian is named after a character of the same name in Douglas Adams' *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*. The current version is 3, while a new version called Trillian Astra is in alpha testing stage. This version can be used from inside the browser, which will make it work in other operating systems. Download the free version from www.trillian-messenger.net.

Trillian has functionalities from basic chat to more advanced voice chat and webcam support. Apart from supporting multiple